



△ Slice of peanut wood, 30cm (12in) long

Peanut wood

Also called **Teredo wood**, peanut wood is a petrified wood with white ovoid markings on its surface, giving it the appearance of peanut brittle. It comes from a conifer that grew around 120 million years ago, mainly in Australia. Its curious appearance is the work of ancient marine animals. A wood-eating clam, *Teredo*, tunnelled into the conifer driftwood, which later sank to the seafloor. White sediment from the shells of tiny plankton then settled over the wood, filling the boreholes with concentrated levels of silicate and creating white tubes when the wood petrified.

Specification

Chemical name Silicon dioxide (white areas), iron oxide (coloured areas) | **Formula** SiO_2 | **Colours** White markings on brown, grey, green | **Structure** Amorphous | **Hardness** 6.5–7 | **SG** 2.58–2.91 | **RI** 1.54 | **Lustre** Vitreous
Location Australia



Good balance of colour

Uncut peanut wood | **Rough** | This chunky piece of peanut wood rough comes from the Gascoyne region of Western Australia. It has an even contrast of light and dark areas.



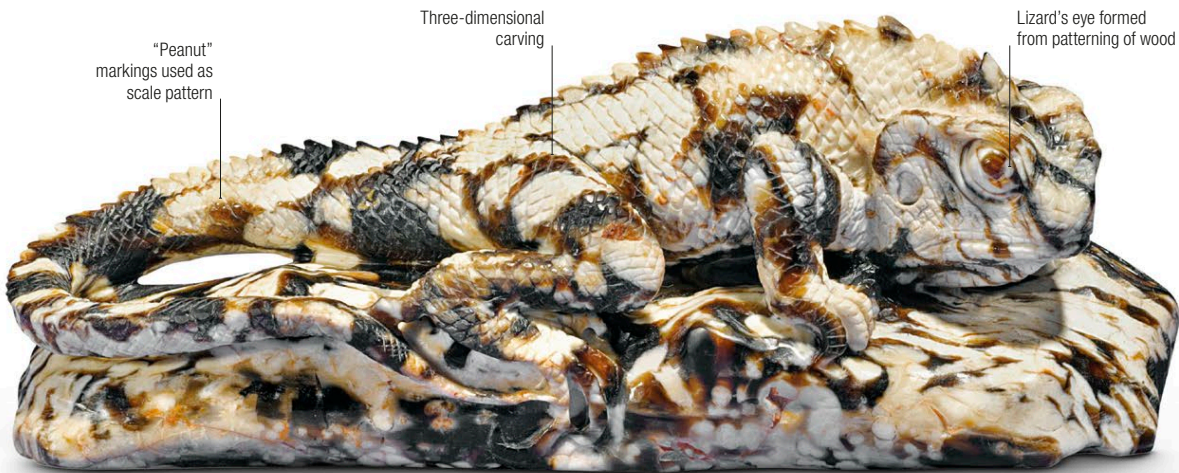
Oriented "peanuts"

Round-cornered cabochon | **Cut** | This rectangular cabochon of peanut wood has been cut along the "peanut" markings to highlight them.



Fossil wood

Round cabochon | **Cut** | This circular gem has been cut to emphasize its unusual 3D-effect markings. The "peanut" shapes are especially evident.



"Peanut" markings used as scale pattern

Three-dimensional carving

Lizard's eye formed from patterning of wood

Lizard ornament | **Carved** | When its pattern is used artistically, as here, peanut wood is a carving medium to rival any. Because it is a form of chalcedony, it is hard and durable, and takes a good polish.



Silver mounting

Smoky quartz

Bracelet | **Set** | This silver bracelet is bezel-set with six Australian peanut wood cabochons and accented by a faceted smoky quartz that suits the colour scheme.